

THE BRAIN AND MENTAL WELL-BEING

New research shows us that yoga changes how our brains work, for the better. Due to the neuroplasticity of our brains (see pp.26–27), these changes demonstrate the potential for yoga to become an effective adjunct to our medical and psychological care.

“”

Yoga gives us the tools to break thought and emotional patterns that no longer serve us.

8 weeks of mindfulness meditation can help reduce fear-related activity in the brain.

Q WHAT DOES YOGA DO TO MY BRAIN?

When your brain becomes accustomed to a well-worn neural path, it becomes a habit, such as mindlessly looking at your phone when you're bored. New neural paths can form in the same way, and repeated activation makes these paths bigger and stronger.

By reinforcing positive behaviors, yoga gives us the tools to break thought and emotional patterns that no longer serve us. This allows the choice of healthier patterns when challenges arise, making yoga a powerful practice for our mental health and well-being.

Q HOW CAN YOGA HELP MY MENTAL WELL-BEING?

Sometimes we get stuck in a rajasic (the energy of agitation), reactionary pattern or a tamasic (the energy of resistance) slump. Yoga alone is not enough to manage a serious mental health concern, but it can be an effective supplement to your medical and psychological care because it affects how your brain responds to mental challenges.

In simplified terms, there are three structures within the brain:

- **The instinctual brain** (brain stem), which asks, “Am I safe?”
- **The emotional brain** (limbic system), which asks, “What am I feeling?”

- **The thinking brain** (frontal cortex), which asks, “What does this mean?”

Under trauma, depression, chronic stress, or anxiety, you may have an overactive emotional brain. Signals from your amygdala (the “fear center” of your emotional brain) encourage fight-or-flight responses from your instinctual brain, causing the stress response to override the relaxation response. When this happens often, your thinking brain is less effective at regulating. Yoga—including asanas, pranayama, and meditation—teaches the thinking brain to better regulate mood and emotional states amid stressors in life (see p.188).